3.2 Southern States Secede

A crack in a mirror often starts out small, hardly visible. But over time, rough handling causes the crack to deepen and run the length of the glass. Pretty soon, the smallest added pressure will make it snap and break in two.

MAIN IDEA The election of Abraham Lincoln as president in 1860 led southern states to secede from the Union.

THE SOUTH DEBATES INDEPENDENCE

The South had reached its breaking point. Abraham Lincoln's victory in the 1860 election shocked and angered most southerners. They were suddenly faced with a northern president who had not won a single southern state. In fact, his name had not even appeared on the ballot in most of them. After all, Lincoln represented a party founded by people who wanted to keep slavery out of new territories and states.

Although Lincoln had not called for the abolition of slavery many proslavery southerners felt certain this was his goal. You've already read one excerpt from Lincoln's "House Divided" speech, delivered in 1858. In that speech he also said, "Either the opponents of slavery will arrest the further spread of it, . . . or its advocates [supporters] will push it forward, till it shall become alike lawful in all the States." In the South, many assumed this meant that Lincoln wished to abolish slavery throughout the United States.

On the day after the election, South Carolina's legislature gathered to debate the possibility of **seceding**, or formally withdrawing from the Union and becoming independent. Secession was not a new idea. Slave states had threatened to leave the Union on numerous occasions. In fact, South Carolina had come very close to doing so during the nullification crisis of the 1830s.

Supporters of secession justified it in terms of states' rights. The right that southern leaders most wanted to protect was their perceived right to own slaves. They argued that under the Constitution, the states retained certain rights,



1860 campaign buttons feature Lincoln (left) and his running mate, Hamlin (right).

including the right to secede. Just as each state had once decided to join the Union, each state could decide to withdraw from it.

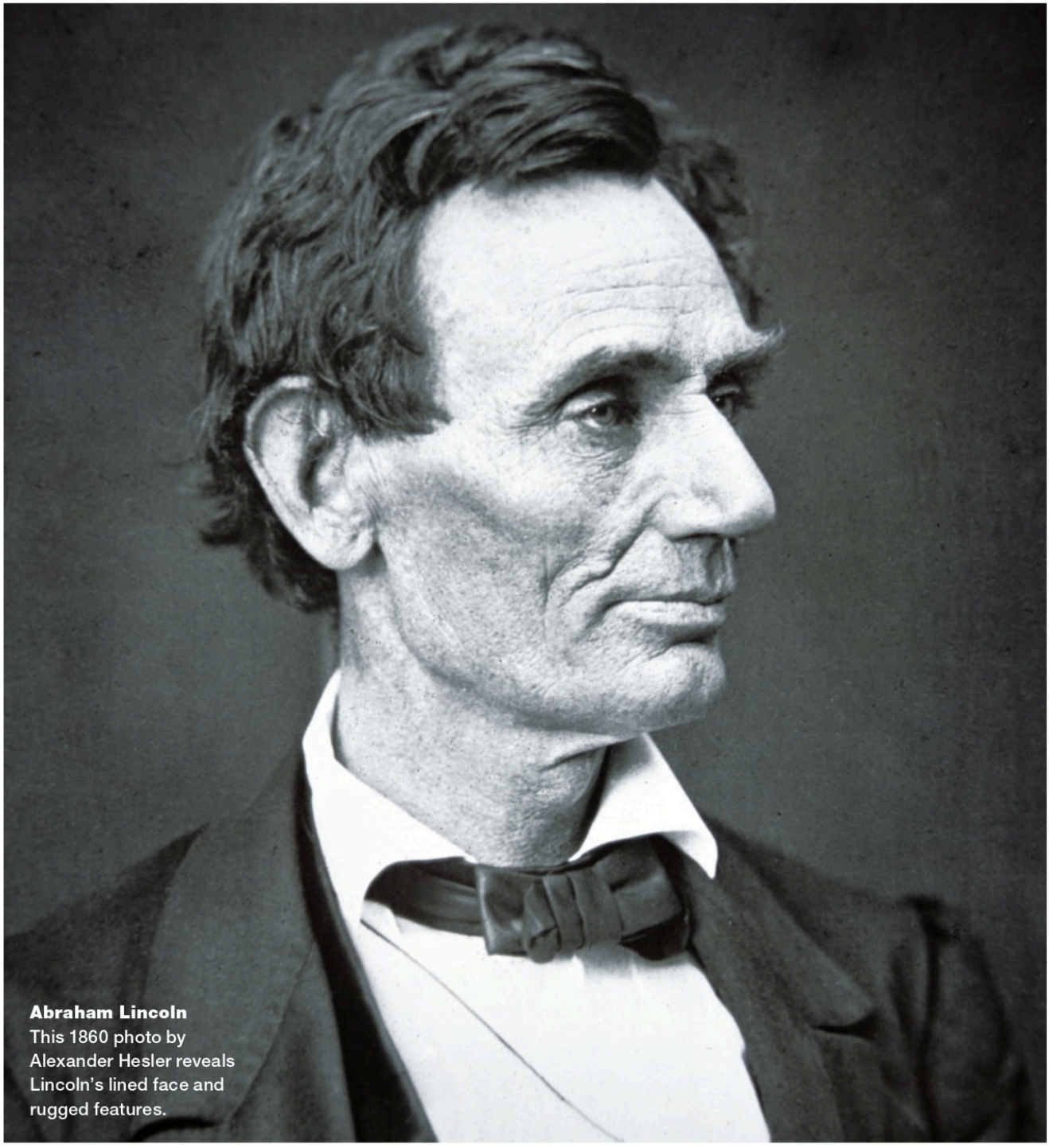
VOTES FOR SECESSION

On December 20, 1860, South Carolina became the first state in the nation to secede from the Union. The state's secession came in response to the presidential election of Abraham Lincoln the month before, even though he was not to take office until March 1861. South Carolina decided that Lincoln's presidential win as a Republican—a party that supported the Free-Soil platform, not the end of slavery in territories where it already existed—signaled that it could not continue as part of the United States.

South Carolina was joined by 10 other states in the coming months. In March 1861, the **Confederate States of America**, or the **Confederacy**, united and quickly formed a temporary government in Montgomery, Alabama, and adopted a new constitution. It was much like the U.S. Constitution, but it protected slavery and states' rights.

Jefferson Davis, a Mississippi senator who had spoken out against secession just weeks earlier, was chosen to be the temporary president of the Confederacy. In his inaugural address, Davis placed the blame for the secessions on the Union,

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Abraham Lincoln
This 1860 photo by Alexander Hesler reveals Lincoln's lined face and rugged features.

arguing that protecting slavery had been the "well-known intent" of the Founders. Meanwhile, the issue of secession was proving to be divisive in the more northern part of the South. Many people opposed secession, calling it treason. They believed secession would be disastrous for the South. Others thought it would be best to wait before making a decision. For the time being, Virginia, Tennessee, North Carolina, and Arkansas remained in the Union. They still held out hope that the differences between the North and the South could be resolved.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did Lincoln's election drive southern states to secede from the Union?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think the Confederacy adopted a constitution that was very similar to the U.S. Constitution?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What fundamental challenge to the Constitution did secession and the doctrine of nullification pose?

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